

You've won a lottery...
Get a free iPhone...
Resize your manhood...
The bigger the better... You can easily recognise these as the subject lines of the delete-worthy mails in your Inbox. However, intriguing subject lines do entice a select few idiots into opening the mails—in case you didn't know.

Creating good spam filters to tackle such mails has been the agenda of many security companies, working with Web-based mail service providers. McAfee recently decided to think outside the box; the company said they would be hiring volunteers from the UK and the US for a thirty-day spam analysis. The research has been dubbed "Super Spam Me." The distasteful thing the volunteers would have to do is to reply to the spam messages; this act will supposedly help the researchers figure how that will affect the flow of spam.

The project, if one may call it that, will only include a few paid volunteers.

Here's the first bit of hilarity: applicants would have to send an e-mail to the company that oversees

Of Change And Small Change

Bidding farewell to Deepak Ajwani as Editor—in fact, as a member of this organisation—was a mixed affair. It was sad for most of us; one or two women wept the way some women do when the time comes to say good-bye. The *chaiwala*, however, was glad, because Deepak never had never given him a tip—we know because he told us.

The outgoing (rather, the out-went) editor had won our minds and hearts by virtue of his genuineness, his big heart, his lack of attitude and ego issues, and his unwillingness to wield the stick of discipline (the above, not in any order—really!). But in particular reference to the last point, we should mention that Nimish and Robert got to play *Quake*, Ram got to sleep, Samir got to use his PSP, Bhaskar got to do his Wikipedia edits, Asfaq

got to chat, Vijay got to surf for exotic pictures, etc. etc.—*during official, paid, office hours*. Still, we should reinforce the idea that this thing about Deepak's not having been strict about discipline was *not* the biggest reason for our loving him.

Robert now manages the things Deepak did, and we'll soon begin to treat him in this space the way we've been treating Deepak. For example, fun shall often be poked at him, and gentle ridicule shall sometimes be directed his way.

We collectively gifted Deepak a good phone, because it's better to give than to receive (*and when you know you won't receive if you ask, it's even better to quietly give*).

Now, a source says Robert hasn't yet given the *chaiwala* a tip either. Surprising: his name doesn't end in "ni"...

DIGIT DIARY

McAfee's PR work. Seeing as the job (namely, to reply to spam messages) is easy to perform, there will doubtless be thousands of volunteers (people tend to like money). The poor slob will now receive more McAfee PR mails than other spam, we can bet.

In case you haven't figured it already, the second point here is that everyone knows what's going to happen. When you respond

to a spam mail, you're going to get more spam—for those not in the know, this is because the spammer gets to know that yours is a valid, active e-mail address. So what's with the bit about analysing how the flow of spam would be affected? If you can guess, if we can guess, McAfee can guess, too—*more spam*, period.

The deal, evidently, is this: get paid to get more spam—from your spammers

as well as from us. Quite normal for a regular Web company to be offering something like this—but not quite normal for a company that should be spending its time making spam filters.

PRIVACY WOES

No more pokey-pokey!

Blog WATCH

Serious issues this month. What's the connection between social networking and large portals? Then, the OLPC project still runs strong in blogging circles... and then, what's gotten into the head of the Chinese government?

Jonathan Bradford and Ian Leader

<http://tinyurl.com/2ogfxk>

http://www.readwriteweb.com/archives/online_accounting_google_apps.php

...So what's next for Google Apps? What might be the next killer app? We think it will be an accounting system and in this article we will outline why. There are strong benefits to an online accounting service in Google Apps—both to users and to the targeted advertising-driven business of Google...every site. What does this have to do with the portals?

...Google could bring significant expertise to online accounting, thanks to their ability to deliver simple, effective online applications with high-performance and reliable infrastructure.

Steve Rubel

<http://tinyurl.com/24n7va>

<http://www.micropersuasion.com/2007/12/wikipedia-and-w.html>

Google announced last night they are starting a project called knol that will allow anyone to create wiki-like pages on topics. In particular, Google is encouraging people who know a particular subject to write an "authoritative" article about it. The search engine will not vet any of the content, however, they will prioritize

the most credible entries and rank them first in search results. It remains unclear how Google is measuring credibility—a scary thought.

...My initial take on this is that knols are going to kill Wikipedia—but it will take time. This theory, however, hinges on whether people actually start creating knols, but I believe they will. Here are several reasons why Wikipedia and Wikia are dead ...

Mark 'Rizzn' Hopkins

<http://tinyurl.com/2gdj5v>

<http://mashable.com/2007/12/13/citizen-journalism-dangerous-and-irresponsible/>

Why are Thomas, Hazinkski, and a growing number of mainstream journalists suddenly saying that those of us who are in the New Media shouldn't be trusted? Has there been some major faux pas that we've committed and didn't know? Did the bloggerati collectively all break one of the "unwritten ethical standards" recently?

No, the impetus for the criticism lately from all sides isn't something we did, it's something CNN did. Those that remember the controversy I caused a few weeks ago even intimating that New Media could be getting a black eye from the Republican YouTube-CNN debates are likely groaning right now, because what I predicted is starting to come to pass...